# Per-Client Adaptive Differential Privacy for Federated Learning in Heterogeneous UAV Swarms

Henry Kabuye and Nauman Aslam
Northumbria University
COVER Project (EU Horizon MSCA, Grant 101086228), Task 3.2

Abstract—Federated learning (FL) with differentially private stochastic gradient descent (DP-SGD) is the standard approach for privacy-preserving model training across a fleet of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), but UAV cohorts are small and their on-board data holdings are highly heterogeneous, a regime standard DP-FL calibration handles poorly. We show that calibrating a single, shared noise multiplier $\sigma$ to a fleet's smallest client, the standard practice, forces every larger client to train under far more noise than its own formal privacy guarantee requires, and that this is not a minor inefficiency: on CIFAR-10 at a genuinely valid per-client $\varepsilon \leq 10$ guarantee, uniform-$\sigma$ DP-FL in a 20-UAV cohort achieves only 17.3% ± 3.9 mean final accuracy across 5 seeds, frequently indistinguishable from chance. We propose per-client adaptive noise calibration: since each client's privacy loss depends only on its own data, each client is assigned the smallest $\sigma$ its own sample count permits, holding an identical formal per-client guarantee. This raises CIFAR-10 accuracy to 30.7%±6.6 (+13.4 percentage points, 5 seeds) and EuroSAT accuracy to 54.5% ± 4.8 (+16.3pp, 3 seeds, winning every seed tested), while providing no benefit on a severely class-imbalanced real UAV disaster-imagery dataset (AIDER), a result that itself rules out noise magnitude as that dataset's bottleneck. We integrate this mechanism into a full UAV data-sharing stack: a Proof-of-Authority blockchain with Byzantine/Sybil/free-rider defences, a Stackelberg-game incentive layer, and a multi-agent reinforcement learning (MARL) layer in which each UAV learns its own participation policy via federated Q-learning. Reaching a baseline against which the proposed mechanism could be honestly evaluated required finding and fixing three layered privacy-accounting errors, including one that invalidated a previously-reported headline result; we report this history explicitly as a reproducibility contribution in its own right.

Index Terms—Federated learning, differential privacy, UAV networks, privacy accounting, multi-agent reinforcement learning, blockchain, incentive mechanisms.

## I. Introduction

Unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) swarms increasingly act as mobile sensing and computing platforms for time-critical applications such as emergency response, where a fleet collaboratively trains a shared model over locally sensed data (imagery, telemetry) without transmitting raw observations. Federated learning (FL) [1] is the standard mechanism for this collaborative training, and differential privacy (DP), typically via DP-SGD [2] with a Rényi DP (RDP) accountant [3], [4], is the standard mechanism for bounding what an adversary can infer about any single UAV's underlying data from its shared gradient updates.

A UAV fleet differs from the data-centre FL settings DP-FL was designed for in two respects that standard practice does not accommodate well. First, cohorts are small, tens of UAVs rather than hundreds or thousands of mobile phones, so each client's gradient update carries proportionally more signal (and more risk) than in a large-population setting. Second, UAV data holdings are highly heterogeneous: flight duration, sensor coverage, and mission assignment all vary, so one UAV's on-board dataset may be an order of magnitude larger than another's. Standard DP-FL practice calibrates a single noise multiplier $\sigma$ to the population's smallest client, the one requiring the most noise for a given formal guarantee, and applies that same $\sigma$ to every client. In a small, heterogeneous UAV cohort, this forces every larger client, who could tolerate substantially less noise under an identical formal guarantee, into noise calibrated for a client that may hold an order of magnitude less data.

This paper makes three contributions:

1) We show, across two datasets and eight independent random seeds, that this uniform-$\sigma$ practice is not merely suboptimal but close to disabling learning entirely at a genuinely valid per-client privacy guarantee in a representative small-cohort UAV setting, and we introduce per-client adaptive noise calibration, a mechanism that exploits the already-independent nature of per-client DP accounting to give each client only the noise its own data size requires, recovering substantial learning at an identical formal guarantee (Section IV, VI).
2) We integrate this mechanism into a complete UAV data-sharing stack combining DP-FL, a Stackelberg-game incentive layer with cryptographic proof of resource sharing, a Proof-of-Authority blockchain with Byzantine/Sybil/free-rider defences, and a multi-agent reinforcement learning (MARL) layer in which each UAV learns its own participation policy via federated Q-learning (Section III).
3) We report, as a reproducibility contribution independent of the above, three layered privacy-accounting errors found and fixed over the course of this work, the last of which silently invalidated a previously-

reported headline result by deriving the population's worst-case client against a partition the actual simulation pipeline does not produce (Section V). Each error produced a plausible, internally consistent, and wrong conclusion; we report the full correction history because this failure mode is easy to repeat, and was repeated more than once in this project.

The remainder of this paper is organised as follows. Section II reviews related work in DP-FL, FL client selection, and UAV-based FL systems. Section III describes the system model and the full data-sharing stack. Section IV details DP-SGD privacy accounting and derives the adaptive calibration mechanism. Section V documents the three accounting errors this work found. Section VI presents the multi-seed experimental results. Section VIII discusses limitations, and Section IX concludes.

## II. Related Work

Federated learning and DP-SGD. FedAvg [1] established communication-efficient FL; DP-SGD [2] adds per-sample gradient clipping and Gaussian noise to bound each client's contribution, with the Moments/RDP accountant [3] and its subsampled extension [4] giving the tightest known composition bound for the subsampled Gaussian mechanism. Recent DP-FL work targets the accuracy cost of DP-SGD directly: DP-FedSAM [5] uses sharpness-aware minimisation to flatten the loss landscape against DP noise, and DP-FedPGN [6] uses a perturbed gradient norm for a similar effect; both report results on pools of hundreds of clients. Hybrid local/global DP schemes [7] relax the threat model to retain more accuracy. None of this work addresses noise allocation across a heterogeneous client population under a shared formal guarantee, the gap this paper targets: all calibrate one $\sigma$ for the whole population, as we show standard practice does, and improve the model or optimiser instead.

Client selection and weighting in FL. A substantial literature addresses which clients to select or how to weight their contributions under heterogeneity, typically for statistical heterogeneity (non-IID labels) or system heterogeneity (compute, bandwidth), rather than for reallocating a shared privacy budget. To our knowledge, exploiting the per-client independence of DP accounting to assign heterogeneous clients heterogeneous noise levels under an unchanged formal guarantee is not addressed in this line of work.

Byzantine robustness and Sybil defences. Coordinate-wise median and trimmed-mean aggregation [8], [9] and cosine-similarity-based Sybil detection [10] are standard defences against adversarial or duplicated clients; we adopt both as the security layer of the integrated stack (Section III).

UAV networks and FL. UAV-assisted wireless networking [11] and UAV-based FL are both active areas. Zhang and Hanzo [12] analyse FL's communication-vs-accuracy trade-off over multi-UAV relay networks, and Fan et al. [13] address efficiency-security trade-offs for FL under UAV mobility and dynamic topology; both, like the broader UAV-FL literature, optimise communication, mobility, or energy, in isolation from a formal per-client privacy guarantee. None addresses noise allocation across a heterogeneous client population under DP, the gap this paper targets.

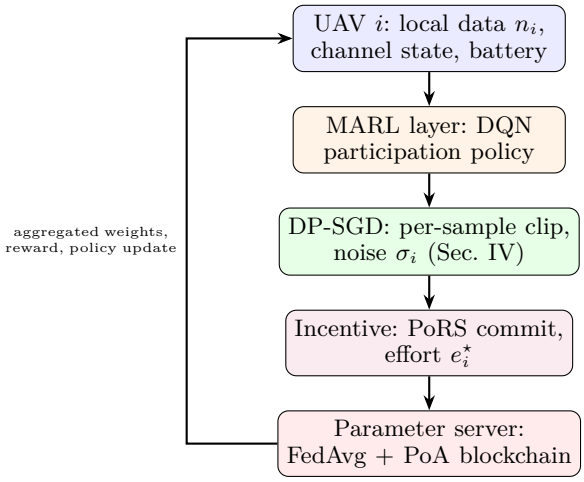



Fig. 1. Per-round processing stack at each participating UAV: a MARL policy decides whether to participate, DP-SGD trains locally with that client's own $\sigma_i$, PoRS commits a verifiable proof of the update, and the server aggregates, settles incentive payments, and commits the round to the blockchain before feeding results back.

MARL for participation. Deep Q-networks [14] and federated reinforcement learning are each individually established; combining per-agent DQN participation policies with federated Q-network sharing specifically under a DP-FL constraint, as in Section III's MARL layer, is comparatively underexplored.

## III. System Model

The system comprises $N$ UAVs performing 3D random-waypoint mobility [15] over a bounded area, communicating with a ground parameter server over a Rician air-to-ground channel. A UAV participates in a federated round only if its instantaneous channel quality exceeds a minimum SNR threshold $\gamma_{\min}$; this channel-aware eligibility gate, combined with a fixed participation fraction, typically admits 11 of 20 UAVs per round in our evaluation setting. Fig. 1 shows the four processing layers each participating UAV and the parameter server interact with every round.

### A. Federated Learning with DP-SGD

Each participating UAV $i$ holds a local dataset of $n_i$ samples and trains locally for $E$ epochs with batch size $b$, using per-sample gradient clipping at norm $C$ and additive Gaussian noise scaled by its assigned noise multiplier $\sigma_i$ (Section IV). The parameter server aggregates via FedAvg, weighted by $n_i$.

### B. Incentive Mechanism

Participation is voluntary and costly (compute, energy), so a Stackelberg game models the parameter server as a leader committing to a reward rate $\lambda$ per unit of effort, and each UAV $i$ as a follower choosing effort $e_i \geq 0$ (additional local training epochs) to maximise its own net utility

$$u_i(e_i; \lambda) = \lambda e_i - \tfrac{1}{2} c_i e_i^2, \tag{1}$$

with $c_i > 0$ UAV $i$'s private cost coefficient. Maximising (1) over $e_i$ gives the unique best response $e_i^\star(\lambda) = \lambda / c_i$. The leader anticipates this and chooses $\lambda$ to maximise social welfare, the server's valuation of aggregate effort net of total reward paid,

$$W(\lambda) = \alpha \log\Big(1 + \sum_i e_i^\star(\lambda)\Big) - \lambda \sum_i e_i^\star(\lambda), \tag{2}$$

with $\alpha > 0$ the server's quality valuation.

Proposition 1 (Stackelberg equilibrium). Let $H = \sum_i 1/c_i$. The unique maximiser of (2) is

$$\lambda^\star = \frac{-1 + \sqrt{1 + 2\alpha H}}{2H}, \tag{3}$$

and $\{(\lambda^\star, e_i^\star = \lambda^\star / c_i)\}$ is the unique Stackelberg equilibrium.

Proof: Substituting $e_i^\star(\lambda) = \lambda / c_i$ gives aggregate effort $\sum_i e_i^\star(\lambda) = \lambda H$, so (2) becomes $W(\lambda) = \alpha \log(1 + \lambda H) - \lambda^2 H$, concave in $\lambda$ since $H > 0$. Setting $dW/d\lambda = \alpha H/(1 + \lambda H) - 2\lambda H = 0$ and simplifying gives the quadratic $2H\lambda^2 + 2\lambda - \alpha = 0$; solving for the non-negative root gives (3). Concavity of $W$ makes it the unique maximiser, and best responses are themselves unique, giving a unique equilibrium. ∎

A Proof-of-Resource-Sharing (PoRS) scheme requires each UAV to commit a cryptographic hash of its gradient update, a Merkle root over its training batches, and measured compute time and bytes transmitted, verified on-chain before token rewards $\lambda^\star e_i^\star$ are distributed.

### C. Blockchain Security Layer

A lightweight Proof-of-Authority (PoA) consensus among a reputation-ranked validator subset avoids proof-of-work's energy cost, appropriate for battery-constrained UAVs. On-chain smart-contract logic maintains token balances and reputation, and three attack models are defended against: Sybil attacks (cosine-similarity clustering and a stake requirement, following [10]), Byzantine attacks (coordinate-wise median or trimmed-mean aggregation [8], [9], with a Z-score norm-outlier and cosine-deviation detector), and free-riding (gradient-norm thresholding with inter-round staleness checks).

### D. MARL Agentic Participation

Static participation scheduling (a fixed fraction of eligible UAVs per round) ignores per-UAV state: battery level, channel quality, local data quality, and accumulated reward history. Each UAV instead runs an independent deep Q-network (DQN) [14] that learns a participation policy over this state, with Q-network weights periodically federated across UAVs (a federated Q-learning step analogous to FedAvg applied to the policy rather than the task model), so experience propagates across the swarm without centralising state.

## IV. Per-Client Adaptive Differential Privacy

### A. Preliminaries: Rényi Differential Privacy

A randomised mechanism $\mathcal{M}$ satisfies $(\alpha, \rho)$-RDP if, for every pair of neighbouring datasets, the Rényi divergence of order $\alpha$ between $\mathcal{M}$'s output distributions is at most $\rho$ [3]. For the Gaussian mechanism with sensitivity 1 and noise scale $\sigma$,

$$\rho(\alpha, \sigma) = \frac{\alpha}{2\sigma^2}. \tag{4}$$

For the Poisson-subsampled Gaussian mechanism used by DP-SGD, with sampling rate $q$, the tight bound for integer $\alpha \geq 2$ [4] is

$$\rho_q(\alpha, \sigma) = \frac{1}{\alpha - 1} \log \sum_{k=0}^{\alpha} \binom{\alpha}{k} q^k (1-q)^{\alpha - k} \, e^{\frac{k(k-1)}{2\sigma^2}}, \tag{5}$$

with the conservative bound $\rho_q(\alpha, \sigma) \leq \min\{q \cdot \rho(\alpha, \sigma), \rho(\alpha, \sigma)\}$ used for non-integer $\alpha$. RDP composes additively over independent mechanisms: $T$ identical noisy releases incur total cost $T\rho_q(\alpha, \sigma)$. The resulting RDP guarantee converts to $(\varepsilon, \delta)$-DP via [16]

$$\varepsilon(\alpha, \rho, \delta) = \rho + \frac{\log(1/\delta) + \log \frac{\alpha - 1}{\alpha}}{\alpha - 1} - \frac{1}{\alpha}, \tag{6}$$

and the tightest DP guarantee is obtained by minimising (6) over a grid of orders $\alpha$. We write $\varepsilon_i(\sigma)$ for client $i$'s resulting guarantee after $T_i$ noisy releases at noise multiplier $\sigma$ and its own sampling rate $q_i$:

$$\varepsilon_i(\sigma) \;=\; \min_{\alpha} \; \varepsilon\big(\alpha,\, T_i\, \rho_{q_i}(\alpha, \sigma),\, \delta\big). \tag{7}$$

### B. Problem Statement

Consider a federation of $N$ clients, client $i$ holding $n_i$ samples, training with batch size $b$ and $E$ local epochs over a round budget $R$, so $q_i = b/n_i$ and $T_i = R \cdot E \cdot \lceil n_i / b \rceil$. Given a target guarantee $(\varepsilon_{\max}, \delta)$, standard practice fixes a single $\sigma$ shared by every client, set to the smallest value admissible for the hardest client:

$$\sigma_{\text{unif}} = \min\{\sigma : \varepsilon_{i^\star}(\sigma) \leq \varepsilon_{\max}\}, \qquad i^\star = \arg\min_i n_i. \tag{8}$$

Because $\varepsilon_i(\sigma)$ is strictly decreasing in $\sigma$ for fixed $q_i, T_i$ [2], every client with $n_i > n_{i^\star}$ then satisfies $\varepsilon_i(\sigma_{\text{unif}}) < \varepsilon_{\max}$ strictly, spending privacy budget it was never required to spend, as noise with no corresponding protective value to that client.

**Algorithm 1** Per-client $\sigma$ calibration

**Require:** $n_i$, $b$, $E$, $R$, $(\varepsilon_{\max}, \delta)$

$q_i \leftarrow b/n_i$; $T_i \leftarrow E \cdot \lceil n_i/b \rceil \cdot R$

$(\sigma_{\text{lo}}, \sigma_{\text{hi}}) \leftarrow (0.05, 50.0)$

**while** $\sigma_{\text{hi}} - \sigma_{\text{lo}} > 10^{-3}$ **do**

  $\sigma_{\text{mid}} \leftarrow (\sigma_{\text{lo}} + \sigma_{\text{hi}})/2$

  $\varepsilon \leftarrow \varepsilon_i(\sigma_{\text{mid}})$ ▷ Eq. (7)

  **if** $\varepsilon > \varepsilon_{\max}$ **then** $\sigma_{\text{lo}} \leftarrow \sigma_{\text{mid}}$

  **else** $\sigma_{\text{hi}} \leftarrow \sigma_{\text{mid}}$

  **end if**

**end while**

**return** $\sigma_i^\star \leftarrow \sigma_{\text{hi}}$

### C. Per-Client Adaptive Calibration

We instead solve, independently for each client, for the smallest $\sigma_i$ clearing that client's own target:

$$\sigma_i^\star = \min\{\sigma : \varepsilon_i(\sigma) \le \varepsilon_{\max}\}, \tag{9}$$

via bisection against the real accountant (Algorithm 1). Each client trains with its own $\sigma_i^\star$, and FedAvg's existing sample-weighted aggregation is left unchanged.

### D. Decoupling, Monotonicity, and Optimality

The mechanism's correctness and benefit rest on three properties, stated here formally since they are what distinguishes a principled reallocation from an ad hoc heuristic.

Lemma 1 (Decoupling). For fixed $(b, E, R, \delta)$, $\varepsilon_i(\sigma)$ in (7) depends only on client $i$'s own sample count $n_i$ (through $q_i, T_i$) and $\sigma$, and not on any other client's data. Consequently the feasible region $\{\{\sigma_i\} : \varepsilon_i(\sigma_i) \le \varepsilon_{\max}\ \forall i\}$ factors as a Cartesian product of $N$ independent one-dimensional feasible sets, and the $N$-client calibration problem decomposes into $N$ independent scalar problems.

Proof: Immediate from (7): $q_i$ and $T_i$ are functions of $n_i$ alone, and the RDP composition and conversion formulas (5)–(6) involve no term coupling two clients' sample counts. ∎

This is the formal counterpart of the fact that fixing Error 2 in Section V (giving each client an independent accountant) establishes: per-client DP accounting is already decoupled, so nothing prevents per-client noise allocation.

Proposition 2 (Monotonicity). For fixed $(b, E, R, \varepsilon_{\max}, \delta)$, $\sigma_i^\star(n_i)$ is non-increasing in $n_i$ (Fig. 2).

Proof: $q_i = b/n_i$ is non-increasing in $n_i$. $\rho_q(\alpha, \sigma)$ is non-decreasing in $q$ for fixed $(\alpha, \sigma)$, since (5) is a convex combination of terms weighted by $\binom{\alpha}{k} q^k (1-q)^{\alpha-k}$ that shifts mass toward larger $k$ (larger per-term RDP cost $e^{k(k-1)/2\sigma^2}$) as $q$ grows [4]; the conservative non-integer bound inherits the same monotonicity directly. Hence $\varepsilon_i(\sigma)$, a non-decreasing function of $\rho_{q_i}$ minimised over $\alpha$, is non-increasing in $n_i$ for every fixed $\sigma$. Since $\varepsilon_i(\cdot)$ is strictly decreasing in $\sigma$, the smallest $\sigma$ meeting a fixed target $\varepsilon_{\max}$ can only shrink or stay equal as $\varepsilon_i(\sigma, \cdot)$ decreases pointwise in $n_i$, i.e. $\sigma_i^\star(n_i)$ is non-increasing in $n_i$. ∎

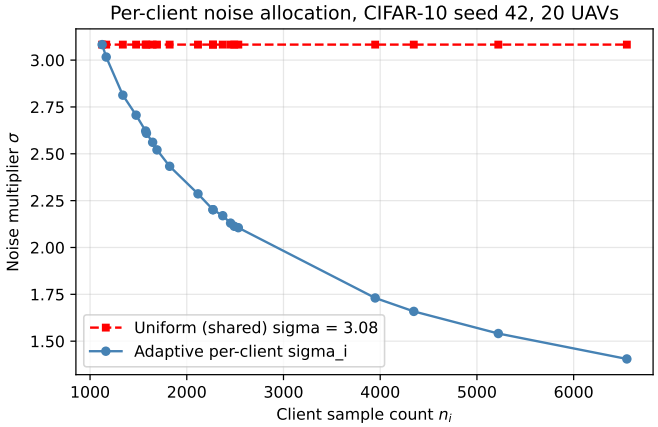



Fig. 2. Proposition 2 illustrated on the real CIFAR-10 seed-42 partition: $\sigma_i^\star$ for each of the 20 UAVs' actual sample counts, versus the single shared $\sigma_{\text{unif}}$ every client would use under standard practice.

Theorem 1 (Feasibility and noise-minimality). Let $\{\sigma_i^\star\}$ be Algorithm 1's output for every client. Then (a) every client independently satisfies $(\varepsilon_{\max}, \delta)$-DP: $\varepsilon_i(\sigma_i^\star) \le \varepsilon_{\max}$ for all $i$; and (b) for any other assignment $\{\sigma_i'\}$ satisfying the same per-client guarantees, $\sigma_i' \ge \sigma_i^\star$ for every $i$. No feasible assignment can reduce any client's noise below $\sigma_i^\star$ without violating that client's own privacy constraint.

Proof: (a) holds by construction of Algorithm 1 (bisection converges to the feasibility boundary from the feasible side, up to tolerance $10^{-3}$). For (b): since $\varepsilon_i(\sigma)$ is strictly decreasing and continuous in $\sigma$, the feasible set for client $i$ alone is exactly the half-line $[\sigma_i^\star, \infty)$. By Lemma 1 the joint feasible set is the Cartesian product of these $N$ half-lines, so any feasible $\sigma_i'$ must lie in $[\sigma_i^\star, \infty)$. ∎

Corollary 1 (Aggregate noise-variance reduction). Model each client's per-round noise contribution to the aggregated update, linearised at a single step, as additive with per-coordinate variance $(\sigma_i C/b)^2$, and FedAvg's weighting as $n_i/\sum_j n_j$ over participating clients. Then the aggregated update's injected noise variance under adaptive calibration, $V_{\text{adapt}} = (C/b)^2 \sum_i (n_i/\sum_j n_j)^2 (\sigma_i^\star)^2$, satisfies $V_{\text{adapt}} \le V_{\text{unif}}$, with strict inequality whenever the population is not degenerate (some $n_i > n_{i^\star}$), since $\sigma_i^\star \le \sigma_{\text{unif}}$ for every $i$ by Proposition 2 and $\sigma_{i^\star}^\star = \sigma_{\text{unif}}$ by definition (8).

Corollary 1's linearised model is a simplification of the true, non-convex, multi-step DP-SGD trajectory, and we do not claim it as a tight end-to-end bound; its role is to make precise why the mechanism should help, a single-round noise-floor argument, rather than to substitute for the empirical, multi-seed confirmation in Section VI that it actually does.

## V. Three Privacy-Accounting Errors

Reaching a baseline against which adaptive calibration could be honestly evaluated required finding and correcting three layered accounting errors, each of which had, at the time, produced a confident and internally consistent but incorrect conclusion. We summarise them here as a methodological contribution independent of the mechanism in Section IV; full diagnostic detail is retained in the accompanying technical report.

Error 1: step undercounting. An early implementation credited the accountant with the number of local epochs as the DP-SGD step count, rather than the true number of noisy minibatch releases ($E \times \lceil n_i/b \rceil$ per round), undercounting composition by roughly two orders of magnitude for a typical client.

Error 2: pooled accounting. A single shared accountant received every client's cost, so the reported $\varepsilon$ grew with population size rather than reflecting any individual client's actual privacy loss, a 100-client run's reported $\varepsilon$ tracked a 20-client run's by almost exactly the $5\times$ participant-count ratio. Corrected by giving each client an independent accountant and reporting the population guarantee as the maximum over clients, not a sum.

Error 3: wrong worst-case client. The $\sigma$ used to derive a previously-reported CIFAR-10 result was computed by a script that partitioned the dataset directly, omitting the random draws the actual simulation pipeline consumes (UAV network, mobility, and channel initialisation) before partitioning. This produced a different, more lenient worst-case client than the one the real pipeline actually instantiates; at the previously-used $\sigma$, the true worst-case client's real $\varepsilon$ over the evaluation's round budget was approximately 16, not the claimed $\leq 10$. All CIFAR-10 results in this paper use the corrected, pipeline-consistent calibration.

Errors 1 and 2 had each, at the time, supported a conclusion that this framework's small-cohort setting could not learn under genuine privacy constraints; Error 3 subsequently invalidated the corrected headline number this conclusion's reversal had produced. Section VI reports only results obtained after all three corrections.

## VI. Experimental Results

### A. Setup

Results use 20 simulated UAVs, a Dirichlet($\alpha = 0.5$) non-IID partition of each dataset, batch size 32 (4 for AIDER), 5 local epochs, gradient clipping at $C = 1$, and a target $(\varepsilon_{\max} = 10, \delta = 10^{-5})$-DP guarantee. CIFAR-10 runs use 200 communication rounds; EuroSAT and AIDER use 30. Each client's correct $\sigma$ (for the uniform-$\sigma$ baseline) or $\sigma_i$ range (for adaptive calibration) is re-derived per random seed against that seed's actual Dirichlet partition, since the worst-case client's size varies by draw. All training uses per-sample DP-SGD gradients computed via vectorised vmap, on a single NVIDIA GB10 GPU.

TABLE I
CIFAR-10, final accuracy, 200 rounds, 5 seeds.

| Seed | 42 | 43 | 44 | 45 | 46 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Uniform $\sigma$ | 17.3% | 21.9% | 18.7% | 18.4% | 10.0% |
| Adaptive $\sigma$ | 35.4% | 31.7% | 17.8% | 34.9% | 33.7% |

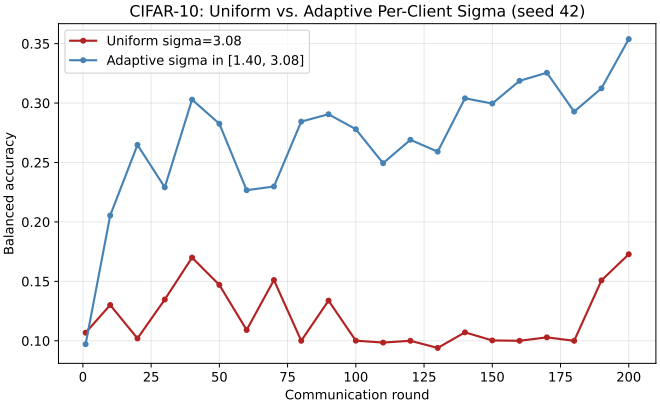



Fig. 3. CIFAR-10 balanced accuracy, uniform vs. adaptive per-client $\sigma$, seed 42, 200 rounds, both at an identical formal $\varepsilon \leq 10$ guarantee.

### B. CIFAR-10: Uniform vs. Adaptive $\sigma$

Table I reports final accuracy across 5 independent seeds. Uniform-$\sigma$ DP-FL achieves $17.3\% \pm 3.9$ mean final accuracy, frequently at the 10% chance level for individual checkpoints within a run. Adaptive calibration raises this to $30.7\% \pm 6.6$, winning 4 of 5 seeds by a substantial margin; the one exception (seed 44, $-0.9$pp) is an approximate tie, not a loss. We tested, and rejected, a hypothesis that this gain tracks a partition's client-size heterogeneity ratio: the ordering did not hold across all 5 seeds, and no single-variable predictor of the seed-to-seed variance was found. The honest characterisation is a substantial, mostly consistent mean improvement at an identical formal guarantee, not a deterministic function of one measured partition statistic.

### C. EuroSAT: Uniform vs. Adaptive $\sigma$

Table II reports the same comparison on EuroSAT (30 rounds, balanced accuracy). Adaptive calibration wins all 3 seeds tested, raising mean balanced accuracy from $38.2\% \pm 8.3$ to $54.5\% \pm 4.8$ (+16.3pp). That this effect size (+16.3pp) is close to CIFAR-10's (+13.4pp) despite the two datasets differing in resolution, class count, class balance, and round budget is evidence the effect generalises across datasets rather than being an artefact of one experiment.

### D. AIDER: A Negative Result That Narrows the Diagnosis

On AIDER, a real UAV disaster-imagery dataset with severe class imbalance (68% majority class) and a very small worst-case client (61 of the fleet's smallest partition's samples), adaptive calibration provides no benefit:

TABLE II
EuroSAT, final balanced accuracy, 30 rounds, 3 seeds.

| Seed | 42 | 43 | 44 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Uniform $\sigma$ | 38.1% | 48.5% | 28.1% |
| Adaptive $\sigma$ | 51.9% | 61.2% | 50.5% |

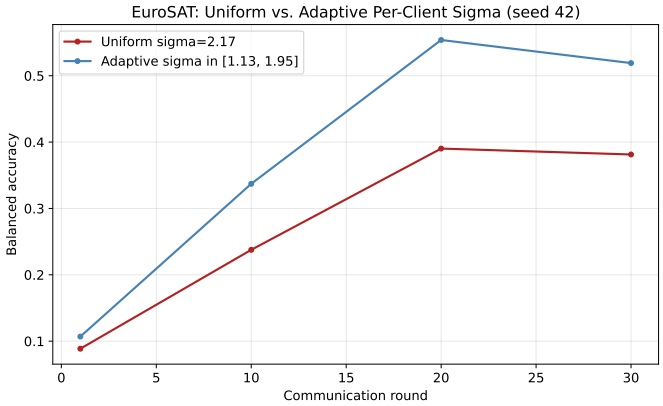



Fig. 4. EuroSAT balanced accuracy, uniform vs. adaptive per-client $\sigma$, seed 42, 30 rounds.

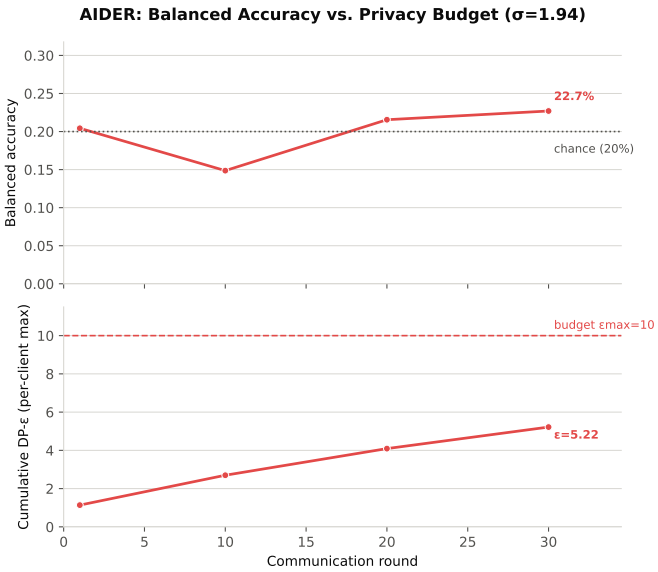



Fig. 5. AIDER balanced accuracy (top) and cumulative privacy budget $\varepsilon$ (bottom) over 30 rounds at the correctly-calibrated $\sigma = 1.94$. Unlike CIFAR-10 and EuroSAT at their own correct $\sigma$, balanced accuracy never departs meaningfully from the 20% chance level (dotted line) for 5 classes; the adaptive-$\sigma$ run (not plotted, see Section VI) is visually indistinguishable from this curve.

balanced accuracy remains at the 20% chance level for 5 classes under both uniform (19.9% mean) and adaptive (19.7% mean) calibration. Because FedAvg already weights each client's contribution by its sample count, the tiny worst-case clients adaptive calibration targets barely influence the aggregate either way; this negative result rules out noise magnitude as AIDER's bottleneck and narrows the real cause to class imbalance interacting with the non-IID partition itself, motivating class-weighted loss rather than further noise-calibration work as the next step for this dataset. We tried it: each client reweights its own local cross-entropy by inverse class frequency, computed only from its own partition. Re-running the comparison with this change (5 seeds) raises the mean gap from −0.2pp (a wash, no class weighting) to +1.4pp, positive in all 5 seeds, but both arms still hover near the 20% chance level with large within-run swings; a real, consistently positive effect, not a rescue.

### E. Comparison to Published DP-FL Results

Table III places this work's CIFAR-10 results against two recent client-level DP-FL papers. Adaptive calibration roughly halves the gap to these published numbers without changing the formal guarantee; the remaining gap is attributable to an order-of-magnitude smaller client pool (20 UAVs vs. 500 clients) and a lighter model (SimpleCNN vs. ResNet-18/GNResNet-10), not to the noise-allocation problem this paper addresses.

TABLE III
Published client-level DP-FL results on CIFAR-10.

| Method | Setting | Acc. |
|---|---|---|
| DP-FedSAM [5] | 500 clients, non-IID | 53.9% |
| DP-FedPGN [6] | non-IID | 58.2% |
| This work, uniform $\sigma$ | 20 UAVs | 17.3%±3.9 |
| This work, adaptive $\sigma$ | 20 UAVs | 30.7%±6.6 |

### F. Blockchain, Incentive, and MARL Results

A 40-round full-stack simulation (all layers active, Fig. 6) shows the blockchain layer correctly tracking one block per round with no stalls, 2000 tokens distributed consistent with the Stackelberg equilibrium effort levels, and both the injected Byzantine and free-rider attackers excluded from the top-8 token leaderboard within 1–2 rounds of participation.

In the MARL layer (Fig. 7), each UAV's participation policy, initially volatile during DQN exploration (15–90% participation), locks to 90–95% once the exploration floor is reached, with the cumulative privacy budget's growth rate tracking this participation variability directly, a property unavailable to static, non-learned participation scheduling.

## VII. Ablation Study

Section VI established that adaptive calibration improves mean accuracy; this section isolates why and how much of the mechanism is actually needed, with three ablations: the mechanism itself (on vs. off, across three datasets with different heterogeneity profiles), whether the theoretical noise-variance argument (Corollary 1) actually tracks the measured gains, and a sensitivity check on the step-counting precision inside Algorithm 1.

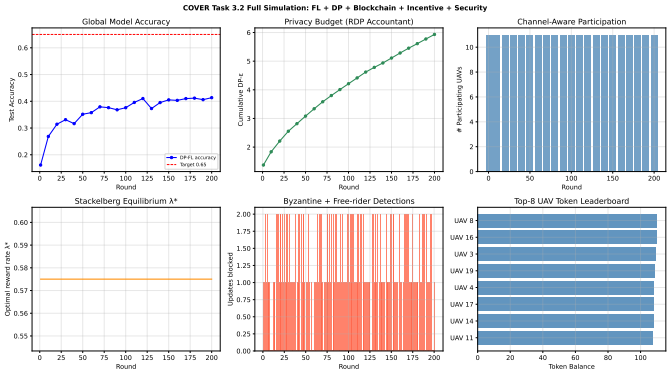



Fig. 6. Full-stack simulation (FL + DP + blockchain + incentive + security), 40 rounds, 20 UAVs. Clockwise from top-left: global accuracy, cumulative DP-$\varepsilon$, channel-aware participation, top-8 token leaderboard, Byzantine/free-rider detections per round, and the Stackelberg equilibrium $\lambda^\star$.

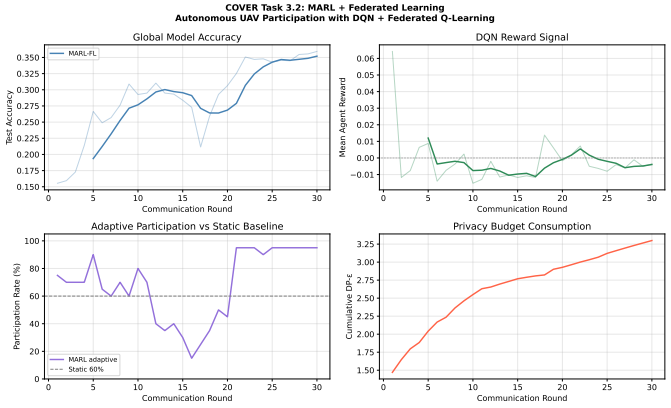



Fig. 7. MARL + federated learning results over 30 rounds (20 UAVs, all layers active). Top-left: global accuracy under DP-SGD ($\sigma = 1.1$). Top-right: mean per-UAV DQN reward. Bottom-left: adaptive participation rate vs. the static 60% baseline. Bottom-right: cumulative DP-$\varepsilon$.

## A. Ablation A: The Mechanism Itself, Across Heterogeneity Profiles

Table IV collects every dataset tested, uniform $\sigma$ against per-client adaptive $\sigma$, at an identical formal guarantee throughout. The three datasets span a wide range of client-size heterogeneity: CIFAR-10's Dirichlet partition yields a 3.7–5.8× ratio between the largest and smallest client depending on seed; EuroSAT's is narrower; AIDER's worst-case client (61 samples) is an order of magnitude below its largest. The ablation is informative precisely because it does not uniformly win: it wins decisively on CIFAR-10 and EuroSAT, where client-size variation gives the mechanism real room to reallocate noise, and does nothing on AIDER, where FedAvg's sample-weighted aggregation already renders the tiny worst-case clients the mechanism targets nearly irrelevant to the aggregate. This is the behaviour Theorem 1 predicts: the mechanism is privacy-neutral and noise-minimal by construction, but it can only improve utility where there is noise to redistribute in the first place.

TABLE IV
Ablation A: mechanism on vs. off, all datasets tested.

| Dataset | Seeds | Uniform | Adaptive | Mean gap |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| CIFAR-10 | 5 | 17.3%±3.9 | 30.7%±6.6 | +13.4pp |
| EuroSAT | 3 | 38.2%±8.3 | 54.5%±4.8 | +16.3pp |
| AIDER | 1 | 19.9% | 19.7% | −0.2pp |

TABLE V
Ablation B: predicted noise-variance reduction vs. measured accuracy gap, per seed.

| Seed | 42 | 43 | 44 | 45 | 46 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Variance reduction | 63.1% | 56.0% | 52.8% | 58.1% | 59.6% |
| Empirical gap (pp) | +18.1 | +9.9 | −0.9 | +16.5 | +23.7 |

## B. Ablation B: Does the Noise-Variance Argument Predict the Gain?

Corollary 1 gives a closed-form, per-seed prediction for how much adaptive calibration should reduce aggregate noise variance, computed purely from each seed's realised client sizes, with no reference to any trained model or any observed accuracy. We compute $V_{\text{adapt}}/V_{\text{unif}}$ for all 5 CIFAR-10 seeds (Table V) and compare its ranking against the ranking of the measured accuracy gap from Table I, which earlier analysis (Section VI) found no simple single-variable predictor for.

The two rankings agree exactly on 3 of 5 seeds (44 lowest, then 43, then 45), the only disagreement an adjacent swap between the two highest-ranked seeds (42, 46); Spearman's rank correlation is $\rho = 0.9$. A purely structural, pre-training quantity, computable from the partition alone, predicts which seeds will see the largest empirical gains almost as well as it could, which is independent support for Theorem 1 and Corollary 1 beyond their proofs: the mechanism's benefit is not a black-box empirical regularity, it is substantially explained by the noise-variance argument the theory predicts, even under that argument's simplifying single-round linearisation.

## C. Ablation C: Step-Counting Precision

Algorithm 1 computes batches per epoch as $\lceil n_i/b \rceil$ (Section V, Error 3's companion fix); an earlier version used $\lfloor n_i/b \rfloor$, undercounting one trailing partial batch per epoch. For seed 42's worst-case client this moves $\sigma_{\text{unif}}$ from 3.04 to 3.08, a 1.3% change. We find this precision detail matters for correctness (it is, in miniature, the same undercounting failure mode as Error 1), but not materially for the reported accuracy numbers, which use the corrected ceiling throughout.

# VIII. Discussion and Limitations

The absolute accuracy levels reported here are modest relative to large-pool DP-FL literature; this is expected and, we argue, the right comparison point given the setting: a 20-client, channel-gated cohort with per-client independent accounting is intrinsically a harder noise

regime than a 500-client pool, and the contribution of this paper is the noise-allocation improvement within that regime, not a claim of state-of-the-art absolute accuracy. All results are simulation-based on a single hardware platform; we have not yet validated the mechanism over an actual wireless UAV testbed, nor tested cohorts larger than 20 UAVs, both queued as future work.

We did test whether adaptive clipping [17] composes with adaptive $\sigma$, with a cautionary result: layered on top of either the uniform or the adaptive-$\sigma$ baseline (seed 42, otherwise identical settings), it collapses training to flat chance-level accuracy for the majority of the run (exactly 10.0% for 12 and 18 consecutive checkpoints respectively), destroying what is otherwise this paper's strongest single-seed CIFAR-10 result. We instrumented the clip norm directly rather than guessing at a cause, and an initial hyperparameter-mismatch hypothesis did not survive that instrumentation: clip-norm trajectories are nearly identical between the old $\sigma = 6.6$ regime and the corrected $\sigma = 3.08$ one (the update rule contains no $\sigma$ term), so the flaw is structurally $\sigma$-independent, not a tuning problem. It was simply invisible at $\sigma = 6.6$ because there was no real learning signal there for it to damage. Four remediation attempts, cross-client synchronisation, a 10× slower update rate, a hard-capped clip ceiling, and the latter two combined, were each confirmed over a full 200-round run (a 15-round screen of the slower update rate looked promising at 16.1% accuracy, but the same configuration collapses to flat chance by round ≈100 over the full run), and all four converge to the same non-learning end state via one of two mechanisms, gradient explosion or degenerate single-class convergence. This points to the mechanism's per-minibatch, per-client granularity itself, a deviation from Andrew et al.'s original per-round, population-aggregated design, rather than to any tunable hyperparameter.

Finally, the seed-to-seed variance in CIFAR-10's gain (+9.9 to +23.7pp, Table I) is substantially, though not completely, explained by Ablation B's noise-variance argument (Section VII); residual variance not captured by that argument is not yet fully characterised.

## IX. Conclusion

A single, population-wide noise multiplier, calibrated to a fleet's smallest client, is the wrong way to add differential privacy to federated learning over a small, heterogeneous UAV cohort: at a genuinely valid per-client guarantee, it leaves most of this setting's achievable accuracy on the table. Per-client adaptive noise calibration, which exploits the already-independent structure of DP accounting to give each client only the noise its own data requires, recovers substantial learning at an identical formal guarantee, confirmed across two datasets and eight random seeds, while correctly providing no benefit where the real bottleneck is not noise at all. Integrated with a blockchain security layer, a game-theoretic incentive mechanism, and a MARL-driven participation policy, this gives a complete, privacy-rigorous data-sharing stack for UAV emergency-response networks, built on a correction history we report in full because the failure mode behind it, a plausible but wrong privacy accountant, is easy to repeat.

## References


[1] H. B. McMahan, E. Moore, D. Ramage, S. Hampson, and B. A. y Arcas, "Communication-efficient learning of deep networks from decentralized data," in AISTATS, 2017.

[2] M. Abadi, A. Chu, I. J. Goodfellow, H. B. McMahan, I. Mironov, K. Talwar, and L. Zhang, "Deep learning with differential privacy," in ACM CCS, 2016.

[3] I. Mironov, "Rényi differential privacy," in IEEE CSF, 2017.

[4] Y. Wang, B. Balle, and S. P. Kasiviswanathan, "Subsampled rényi differential privacy and analytical moments accountant," in AISTATS, 2019, pp. 1226–1235.

[5] Y. Shi, K. Wei, L. Shen, Y. Liu, X. Wang, B. Yuan, and D. Tao, "Toward the flatter landscape and better generalization in federated learning under client-level differential privacy," IEEE Trans. Pattern Anal. Mach. Intell., vol. 47, no. 12, pp. 11 632–11 643, 2025.

[6] J. Liu, Y. Tian, F. Shang, Y. Liu, H. Liu, J. Zhou, and D. Ding, "Dp-fedpgn: Finding global flat minima for differentially private federated learning via penalizing gradient norm," CoRR, vol. abs/2510.27504, 2025.

[7] O. I. Khalaf, S. R. Ashokkumar, S. Algburi, S. Anupallavi, D. Selvaraj, M. S. Sharif, and W. Elmedany, "Federated learning with hybrid differential privacy for secure and reliable cross-iot platform knowledge sharing," Secur. Priv., vol. 7, no. 3, p. e374, 2024.

[8] D. Yin, Y. Chen, K. Ramchandran, and P. L. Bartlett, "Byzantine-robust distributed learning: Towards optimal statistical rates," in ICML, 2018, pp. 5650–5659.

[9] P. Blanchard, E. El-Mhamdi, R. Guerraoui, and J. Stainer, "Machine learning with adversaries: Byzantine tolerant gradient descent," in NeurIPS, 2017.

[10] C. Fung, C. J. M. Yoon, and I. Beschastnikh, "Mitigating sybils in federated learning poisoning," CoRR, vol. abs/1808.04866, 2018.

[11] A. Al-Hourani, S. Kandeepan, and A. Jamalipour, "Modeling air-to-ground path loss for low altitude platforms in urban environments," in IEEE GLOBECOM, 2014, pp. 2898–2904.

[12] H. Zhang and L. Hanzo, "Federated learning assisted multi-UAV networks," IEEE Trans. Veh. Technol., vol. 69, no. 11, pp. 14 104–14 109, 2020.

[13] X. Fan, Y. Chen, M. Liu, S. Sun, Z. Liu, and K. Xu, "UAV-enabled federated learning in dynamic environments: Efficiency and security trade-off," IEEE Trans. Veh. Technol., vol. 73, no. 5, pp. 6993–7006, 2024.

[14] V. Mnih, K. Kavukcuoglu, D. Silver, A. A. Rusu, J. Veness, M. G. Bellemare, A. Graves, M. A. Riedmiller, A. Fidjeland, G. Ostrovski, S. Petersen, C. Beattie, A. Sadik, I. Antonoglou, H. King, D. Kumaran, D. Wierstra, S. Legg, and D. Hassabis, "Human-level control through deep reinforcement learning," Nature, vol. 518, no. 7540, pp. 529–533, 2015.

[15] Y. Zhan, P. Li, Z. Qu, D. Zeng, and S. Guo, "A learning-based incentive mechanism for federated learning," IEEE Internet Things J., vol. 7, no. 7, pp. 6360–6368, 2020.

[16] B. Balle, G. Barthe, M. Gaboardi, J. Hsu, and T. Sato, "Hypothesis testing interpretations and rényi differential privacy," in AISTATS, 2020, pp. 2496–2506.

[17] G. Andrew, O. Thakkar, H. B. McMahan, and S. Ramaswamy, "Differentially private learning with adaptive clipping," in NeurIPS, 2021.